

“Now, more than ever, jewels can have a unique, personal significance for us all”



a time, the economy of Whitby in North Yorkshire – the principal, local source of jet – revolved around the production of items for this sombre trade.

The work of skilled lapidaries and carvers can also be seen in buildings, such as the mysterious Russian Amber Room – treasure-hunters have searched in vain for this enigmatic piece, so far without success. Elsewhere, the Alhambra in Spain and the Taj Mahal in India both feature stunning carvings in precious and semi-precious materials.

The most common use of jewels, of course, is to be worn. Throughout history, the most powerful figures have competed to own spectacular jewels. In ancient times, it was a matter of pride to be buried along with one's most prestigious possessions, and archaeologists have learned a great deal from the jewellery discovered in high-status graves. Later rulers amassed large collections, sometimes establishing their own mines or creating a monopoly to ensure that they acquired the best examples. In particular, they sought jewels that were exceptional for their size, rarity, or beauty. In the modern era,

lovers of gemstones have placed a greater emphasis on fashion and design. The figures of high society – film stars, royalty, and other celebrities – all want to be photographed wearing an exquisite piece by one of the great names in modern jewellery design – Fabergé, Cartier, Lalique, Tiffany.

Above all, jewels are symbols of romance: throughout the ages, they have been exchanged as love tokens. The finest examples have a history all of their own, passing from one distinguished owner to the next. A huge pearl, *La Peregrina* (“the Pilgrim”), was given to Queen Mary of England in the 1550s, as an engagement present. It was later owned by Margaret of Austria and Joseph Bonaparte of Spain, before eventually Richard Burton purchased it for Elizabeth Taylor.

Fortunately, not every love token costs a king's ransom. Wedding rings have been presented since ancient Egyptian times but, from the early 20th century, it has become fashionable to give jewellery with birthstones or anniversary stones on special occasions. Now, more than ever, jewels can have a unique, personal significance for us all.